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BME 195 Immunoengineering

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20 March 2025

Next-Generation Vaccine Platforms: Enhancing Immune Response and Antigen Stability Against SARS-CoV-2 Variants

Abstract

The rapid emergence of SARS-CoV-2 variants has posed challenges to vaccine efficacy due to immune escape, where mutations enable the virus to evade pre-existing immunity. To address this, researchers are developing next-generation vaccine platforms that enhance immune response amplification, antigen stability, and protection against immune escape. Both studies present promising strategies, though future research could explore combining enhanced antigen delivery with robust immune modulation to develop more effective, long-lasting COVID-19 vaccines.

Introduction

The COVID-19 pandemic highlights the urgent need for effective and adaptable vaccines. SARS-CoV-2 continues to evolve with rapid mutations in the spike protein contributing to immune escape and reduced vaccine efficacy. Current vaccines, primarily based on the SARS-CoV-2 spike protein, generate strong humoral responses

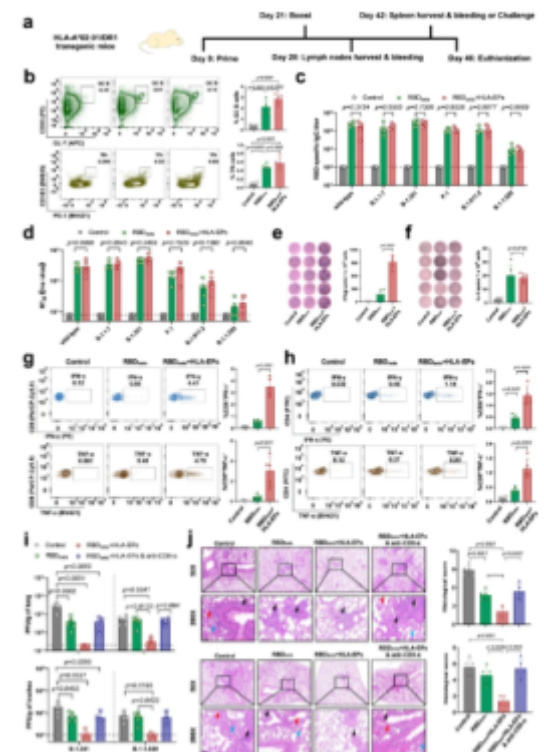
but struggle to provide long-term protection against highly mutated variants. As a result, researchers have shifted focus toward developing next-generation vaccine platforms, incorporating DNA and mRNA technologies to improve antigen stability, immune activation, and adaptability.

This paper examines two recent studies addressing these challenges.

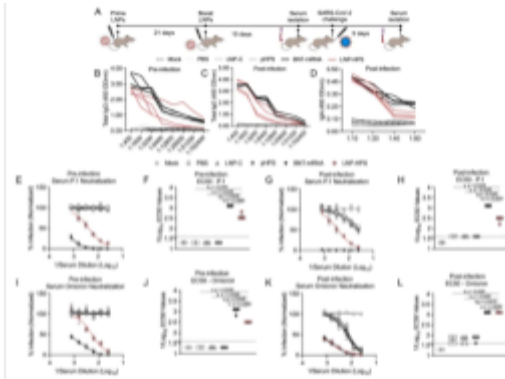
Guimarães et al. (2024) investigate a nanoparticle-based DNA vaccine (LNP-HPS) encoding a stabilized spike protein, evaluating its ability to stimulate broad humoral and cellular immunity against SARS-CoV-2 variants. Tai et al. (2023) explore an mRNA-based vaccine (LNP-HLA-EPs) incorporating HLA-I epitope-enriched peptides, designed to enhance T-cell immunity and protect against immune-evading variants.

Immune System Amplification

Both papers aimed to enhance the immune response amplification, but each explored a different mechanism in their approach. In Guimarães et al., mice were immunized with HexaPro spike proteins (LNP-HPS) and controls. The mice were then examined 5 days post-infection to determine if the LNP-based DNA vaccine induced a significant immune system response. Figure 6 shows a significant increase in anti-spike immunoglobulin G (IgG) and a neutralization of antibodies which indicates a strong humoral response in the mice.



Tai et al. Fig. 3

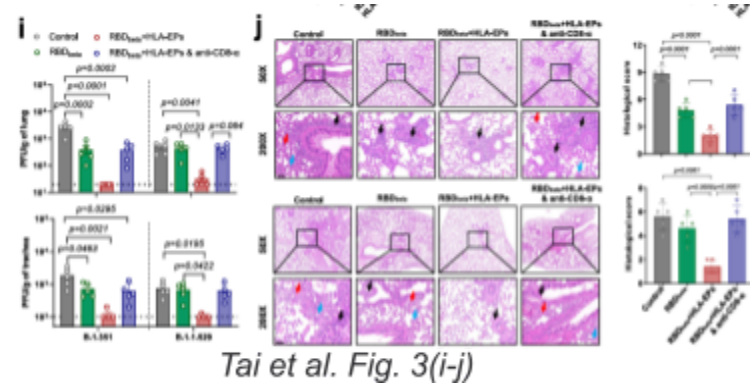


Guimarães et al. Fig. 6

Likewise, in Tai et al., an mRNA-based vaccine was engineered primarily to amplify T-cell immunity which led to a more robust CD8+ T-cell response. Figure 3 shows an enhanced interferon-gamma response in CD8+ T cells in mice. The study confirms a strong cellular immune activation was achieved. All in all, the findings from these two papers highlight how different vaccine platforms can effectively amplify the immune system to protect against SARS-CoV-2 variants.

Resistance Against Immune Escape

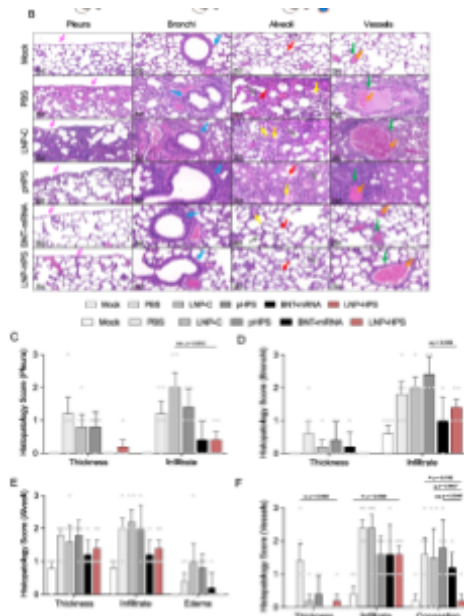
A significant challenge in vaccine development is immune escape, a process in which mutations in SARS-CoV-2 variants enable evasion of existing vaccine-induced immunity. To address this, Tai et al. study



Tai et al. Fig. 3(i-j)

employed humanized

transgenic mice, which were immunized and subsequently challenged with the Beta and Omicron variants. Utilizing Histological analysis of lung tissues four days post-infection (Figure 3, panel i) significantly reduced inflammation and tissue damage in the vaccinated groups compared to unvaccinated controls. Additionally, Figure 3, panel j illustrates lung tissue morphology, demonstrating a notable reduction in dark-stained regions, which correspond to severe inflammation.



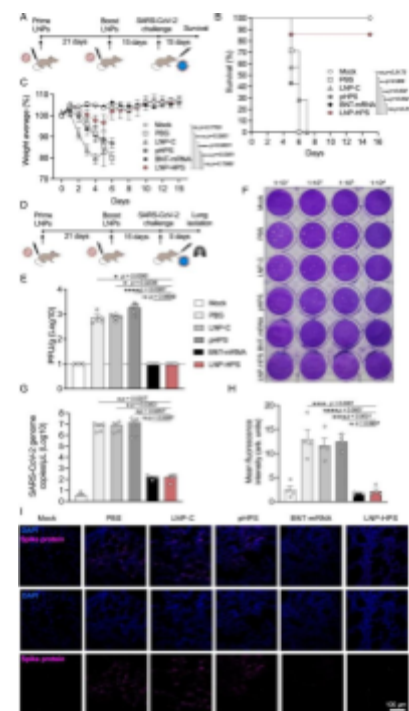
Guimaraes et al. Figure 5 (B-F)

Similarly, Guimarães et al. vaccinated mice challenged with the Gamma (P.1) variant which exhibited marked reductions in lung inflammation and tissue damage relative to unvaccinated controls. This trend is visually represented in Figure 5, panel b, where vaccinated mice show fewer dark-stained regions, indicating reduced pulmonary inflammation. Furthermore, quantitative histological scoring (Figure 5, panels c–f) confirmed significantly diminished inflammatory responses across multiple lung regions in vaccinated mice.

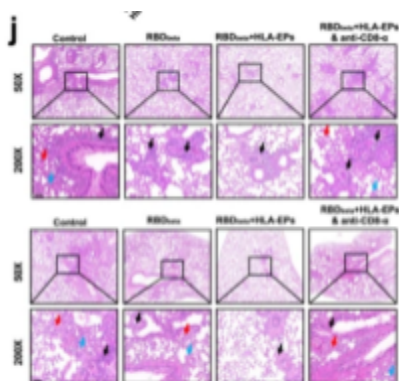
Stability of Nanoparticles

A key challenge for genetic vaccines is protecting fragile DNA and mRNA molecules until they reach target cells. This is where LNP shines. Researchers used cryo-TEM imaging to confirm the structural integrity of LNPs and performed DNase protection assays to test whether LNPs could shield genetic material from degradation. These nanoparticles are uniform in size, with a compact core, indicating stability. The DNase assay further confirms that DNA inside LNPs remains intact, while free DNA is quickly degraded.

Ultimately, the goal of vaccination is protection against



Guimaraes et al., Figure 4B-I



Tai et al. Fig. 3J

infection. Both studies evaluated survival rates, viral load, and lung pathology in vaccinated animals after exposure to SARS-CoV-2 variants. Figures 4B–I of Guimarães et al. show that mice immunized with the DNA vaccine had lower viral loads and less lung damage

compared to controls. These results were comparable to the Pfizer-BioNTech mRNA vaccine. Figure 3J of Tai et al. highlights lung pathology in the mRNA vaccine study, showing that dual immunization with both T-cell and antibody-stimulating antigens provided superior protection against variants.

Conclusion/Future Perspectives

Throughout this presentation, we've examined two studies that contribute to vaccine development in different ways. Guimarães et al. focus on optimizing antigen delivery through engineered LNP, ensuring that mRNA-based vaccines reach immune cells efficiently. While both studies address critical challenges in vaccine development, they remain separate approaches. On the other hand, Tai et al. emphasize immune activation, demonstrating how DNA vaccines can generate strong antibody and T-cell responses. While both studies address critical challenges in vaccine development, they remain separate approaches. There is currently no integration between the advancements in antigen delivery from Guimarães et al. and the robust immune responses observed by Tai et al..

Looking ahead, there are opportunities to combine these two approaches. Future vaccines could integrate the optimized LNP delivery system from Guimarães et al. with the immune-stimulating antigens from Tai et al.. This would create a hybrid system that maximizes both antigen stability and immune activation. This could push the field toward next-generation vaccines with broader protection and longer-lasting immunity.